

TREES AND LARGE SHRUBS

Use the following method to plant container-grown or balled and burlapped trees and large shrubs. Bare-root plants, available through fall and winter, are planted in the same way, but refill around the roots in stages to ensure that you eliminate all the air gaps. Do not add extra fertilizer or organic matter when planting, but prepare the soil well in advance.

Water your tree or shrub using the method described for perennials.

Remove the plant from its container or wrapping. Tease out the roots carefully and scrape away the top layer of soil if the plant is in a pot. Dig a planting hole of the same depth, and up to three times as wide as the root ball, and loosen the sides of the hole with a fork. Place the tree into the hole, ensuring that the area where the roots start to flare out is near the surface. Refill around the root ball, and firm the soil to remove air pockets. Water well.



Planting a tree Plant trees slightly above the soil surface, so the area where the roots flare out from the trunk is just visible. Place a stake over the pot to judge the right depth, and adjust the soil accordingly.



Providing support Trees gain strength by natural flexing and bending. When planted, additional support should not be installed on a tree unless conditions warrant, for example, very loose soil or in an area that receives high winds.



Aftercare After planting, apply a mulch, leaving a space of 4in (10cm) around the trunk. Water consistently for the first two years, and check and loosen tree ties regularly. Remove the tree stake after four years once established.

BULBS

Spring-flowering plants that grow from bulbs, such as daffodils and tulips, are planted in fall, while those that bloom in summer, including gladioli, are planted in spring. Most prefer free-draining soil, so if you have heavy clay, add sharp grit to the area where you plan to plant. Alternatively, bulbs requiring vernalization can be planted in frost-proof pots during fall.

Bulbs can be planted individually, but they look better and are easier to plant in a group. First, dig a wide hole to the appropriate depth. Most bulbs are planted at a depth of three times their height, except for tulips, which are planted at four times their height. For example, a 2in (5cm) daffodil bulb is planted at 6in (15cm), while a 2in (5cm) tulip bulb should be planted at 8in (20cm). Water well after planting.



Planting dormant bulbs Plant bulbs with the pointed tip facing upward. To prevent animals from digging them up, cover the soil after planting with wire mesh. Secure the mesh with stakes.



Planting snowdrops Unlike other bulbs, snowdrops are best planted when in leaf, just after they have flowered in spring. This is known as planting "in the green."